

## CHAPTER ONE

### Land and People

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#### (a) Physical and Anthropological Geography

##### Geography

The geography of Bangladesh is the setting in which the drama of our history has been enacted. Some idea of the geographical setting is therefore necessary for understanding the physical forces which have influenced our culture and history. It is often said that Bangladesh is a small country. This is correct if we compare with very large countries like India and China. However, we may choose to look at Sri Lanka and find that we are twice as big, or at Western Europe and find that Bangladesh is equal in size to the combined areas of Holland, Belgium and Denmark and Switzerland. Therefore size is a relative factor. The area of Bangladesh is 144,000 square kilometres (55,900 square miles). For the purpose of economic exploitation we may also add another 50,000 square kilometres in the Bay of Bengal, which is internationally recognized as our Economic Exploitation Zone (EEZ).

One of the first facts that one should recognize is that Bangladesh has a coastline and therefore an opening to the oceans of the world. This is a very big asset, especially when one considers the logistical, mercantile and geo-political problems of land-locked countries (Rashid 1991). This window to the wider world was known to our ancestors also, who used to make Bangladesh one of the major trading nations of the ancient world. We too should be fully appreciative of the fact that the 1,400 kilometres of coastline which give access to the shipping lanes of the world are one of our geographical assets.

Another major asset is our tropical climate. We are all aware that Bangladesh is a rainy country and has high temperatures most of the year. While this may make us a bit uncomfortable at times it is an asset when we consider the fact that it enables us to grow crops throughout the year and that it provides us with an abundance of water. Many countries of the world are disadvantaged either

by cold winters or lack of rainfall. Those countries, such as Japan and Germany, cannot grow crops for part of the year because of very cold winters. Other countries, such as Egypt and Mexico are constrained because of the lack of rainfall. In Bangladesh we are fortunate that we can grow different crops and trees throughout the year.

Bangladesh is in the North Hemisphere, and is bisected by the Tropic of Cancer (Map-1). The Himalaya Mountains to the north of the country shelter us from the cold, dry winds of Central Asia (Tibet, Mongolia) and therefore we have relatively mild winters. The Himalaya also helps us by blocking the flow of moist winds from the Indian Ocean, which results in copious rainfall in and around Bangladesh. These moist winds from the Indian Ocean blow from April to September and they are known as the Monsoon Winds. Annual rainfall in Bangladesh varies from 60 inches in and around Rajshahi to over 200 inches in and around Sylhet. It may be noted that Bangladesh is drier in the west and wetter in the east. Another fact that one may note is that Bangladesh is in the Desert Belt of the Northern Hemisphere, but its climate is anomalous because it receives so much rain. The great desert such as the Thar, the Arabian, the Nubian, the Sahara and the Mexican are all in this Northern Desert Belt. We are fortunate in having the Himalayas so nearby and the annual flow of the monsoon winds. Without these fortunate factors Bangladesh could also turn into a desert, or at least a semi-arid country. It is because of this that we are afraid of losing our wetlands (*beels, haors*) or having the world climate change which could lead to a weak monsoon wind and less rainfall.

A map of the physical features of Bangladesh shows a large delta in the south, several floodplains, two areas of uplands (Barind and Madhupur Tract) and hill ranges and valleys in the east. This is the surface picture. What is underneath? In order to understand that we have to go back 200 million years. That long ago the rocks deep below the surface of our country were far to the south, as part of a continent known as Gondwanaland. When this continent broke up, part of it travelled north and collided against the Asian continent. This collision led to the formation of the Himalaya and Arakan-Chin mountain ranges. The ancient rocks beneath the surface of Bangladesh are still moving, very very slowly, towards the north-east. This movement causes earthquakes now and then. Earthquakes are a natural hazard which are infrequent but have caused major changes in our surface topography.

The main surface features of Bangladesh are the floodplains of the Ganges, Brahmaputra and Meghna, the delta formed by these three major rivers, two areas of uplands in between these rivers and the hills and valleys in the eastern part of the country (Map 2). The main channel of the Brahmaputra used to flow past Mymensing and Sonargaon towns (Map 3), though now it flows mainly along the Jamuna. This change in its course is supposed to have been set in motion by a massive earthquake in 1772, and the change was complete by 1830. Since then the river flowing past Mymensingh town is known as the Old Brahmaputra.

A look at the map will show that in earlier times there were only relatively small rivers between the ancient urban centers of Mahasthan and Savar, whereas the mighty Brahmaputra formed a significant barrier between Mainamati (Samatata) and the western urban centers. Thus large kingdoms and empires in the western part of our country often had little impact in the east, where smaller kingdoms could therefore flourish. This also had cultural significance, no doubt.

The present day topography of Bangladesh shows that there are two areas of uplands between the major rivers. The upland between the Ganges and Brahmaputra-Jamuna is known as Barind Tract (*Barendra Bhumi*) and the upland between the Jamuna and Meghna is known as the Madhupur Tract (*Bharwal Garh*). These two large areas are quite different from the floodplains, because they flood less frequently and their soil is less fertile. These areas were forested or covered in grasslands till recent times. Even at present the population density is much less there than in the floodplains. An important difference between the two upland tracts is that whereas parts of the Barind were settled and urbanized long ago Madhupur tract remained largely a forested area till very recent times.

The large rivers combine, one with the other, as they flow south towards the sea, and they branch out with Distributary Rivers. These rivers form a trelliswork of rivers in the shape of a triangle which is known as a delta. The delta of the Ganges-Brahmaputra-Meghna is the largest delta in the world. This is an area where river flows are affected by ocean tides, and the saline water of the Bay of Bengal may even penetrate a hundred miles inland. The delta is an area of very new soils and inevitably sinks slightly every year due to compaction of these new soils. Therefore it is essential that fresh deposits of river sediment are allowed to build up this part of our country. All along the sea-face of this delta we used to have the Sunderban forest, but the Sunderban in Patuakhali district was cleared a hundred years ago, and now we have the famous Sunderban forest only in the western sea-face of the delta.

In the eastern part of our country there are many hills and valleys, beginning with a thin strip along the border at the foothills of the Meghalaya and broadening out to include the whole of the Chittagong region in the southeast. No less than 12.5 percent (one-eighth) of Bangladesh is covered with hills and valleys. In the southeast we have an area between the Muhuri River in the north and Naaf River in the south known in geographical literature as the Chittagong Region. This area faces the Bay of Bengal in the west and has a succession of hill ranges running south to north. These hill ranges rise to mountain heights of 3000 feet or more in some places. In the cultural history of Bangladesh this area is very important because it links ancient Bengal to ancient Myanmar through the Arakan kingdoms. This link was both overland and by sea, and it brought together Bengalis, Arabs, Rakhine and other people in the peaceful pursuit of artisan industries and commerce.

The city of Chittagong is important as a major urban centre, a major industrial area, the most important seaport of the country and also a very important historical place. From the ruins of Ramkot (near Ramu), which is mentioned by the 2<sup>nd</sup> century A. D. the geographer Ptolemy, the Buddhists art works from Silua near Feni, and indications that the famous Pandita Vihara may have been somewhere in the area of Chittagong city itself, we may surmise that the Chittagong Region played an important part in our ancient history. Its importance was enhanced when the manufacturers of Bangladesh, mainly textiles, became important in international trade. The growth of this trade can be traced back to the 8<sup>th</sup> century A. D., but its heyday was from the 13<sup>th</sup> to the 18<sup>th</sup> century. Chittagong played a key role in developing and nurturing this trade.

### Anthropology

A look at a map of southern Asia (Map 1); will show that Bangladesh is very strategically located. To her north are the Himalaya Mountains, the very high plateau of Tibet, the Gobi desert and then the inhospitable stretches of Mongolia and Siberia. To her south is the Bay of Bengal, which opens out in to the Indian Ocean. In this part of the world Bangladesh provides the only relatively easy land crossing between the western and eastern parts of Asia. It is said that the origin of human beings is Africa, but that some of them moved into the northern part of the Middle East and then dispersed across the world from areas in the northern part of the Middle East. In this dispersal the people who went to Southeast Asia and Australia, more than 50,000 years ago, are surmised to have traversed the country that is now Bangladesh. Some of them may have remained behind but as yet we have no evidence of that. Among the people who walked into the valleys and floodplains of Southeast Asia some developed languages which are known as Austric languages. Present-day examples of such languages are Khmer (spoken mainly in Cambodia) and Mone (spoken by some groups in Myanmar). From the evidence of a few words in Bangla (e.g. *Langal*), some artifacts (e.g. scrapers) and some agricultural crops (e.g. *Kochu* = arum) we may surmise that these people speaking Austronesian languages came from the east in to the area of Bangladesh several thousand years ago (Map 4). Certain very early finds of Bronze tools and rice seeds in northeast Thailand suggests that these people may have also introduced rice cultivation into our area. At the same time or somewhat after some other people, whom we now classify as early Mongoloid (that is, closely related to the Burmese and Thai) also entered Bangladesh and spread mainly into the uplands and hilly areas.

Bangladesh is a melting-pot of ancient peoples. They came by land routes, across mountains, down river valleys and also possibly by boats along the coast. Though some of the early groups who made a significant impact came from the east the main peopling of this land was by those who came from the southern and western parts of the South Asian subcontinent, and they are known as

Dravidians. Actually they were a physically diverse people, probably speaking different languages, which may have all belonged to the Dravidian family of languages; we do not as yet know much about them. It is said that even within historic times many people in Bangladesh spoke a language related to Telegu, which is a Dravidian language. Then again the physical features of the majority of the present day people shows an affinity with those of eastern India who have a more definite Dravidian background. It should be mentioned that the Dravidian language speakers were mostly a Caucasoid people, which means in hair form and other physical features they resemble the people of the Middle East more than they resemble the people of East Asia. However they are generally darker than the different peoples to the east and west of South Asia.

The latest arrivals were a people well known as the Aryans. They spoke a language of the Indo-European family of languages and they are said to have originated from the northern parts of the Middle East and the eastern parts of Europe. They came in to South Asia around 1200 B C and flourished in the area now known as Haryana 'Land of the Aryans'. Over the centuries they mixed with the Dravidians and settled in the relatively drier parts of the Ganges Valley. With the adoption and spread of rice cultivation this mixed population of Aryo-Dravidians moved in to the Bengal Basin some time after 600 B.C. and laid the foundations of urbanization in our country. They in turn mixed with the Austric and Mongoloid peoples already in Bangladesh and produced the physical types which are so common nowadays.

Bangladesh has been the focus of immigration since those times till recently. The cultivation of wet-rice (as opposed to hill-rice), where fields have to be levelled and dyked (with *aïls*) and then swampland varieties of rice cultivated in watery conditions, enabled the immigrants to adapt to the wet monsoon conditions of Bangladesh and at the same time to obtain sufficient food to feed large families. They also evolved a variety of boats and fishing gear and exploited the abundant fish stocks. Whereas these resources encouraged rapid growth of population there were also severe checks in the forms of malaria, cholera and typhoid. On balance the population grew, and parts of the country became quite thickly populated. Indeed for the past one thousand years Bangladesh has been known as one of the more populated parts of the world. Bangladesh was also, to our surprise, one of the wealthiest countries of the world. The commercial opportunities attracted many immigrants, some peaceful, such as the Arab merchants along the coast, others warlike, such as the Turks and Pathans, in the urban centers between Gaur and Sonargaon. These people too added their physical stock to the melting-pot, so that today we have in Bangladesh a great variety of physical features. The Bengali ancestry includes the Austric-speakers, the Mongoloids, the Dravidians and Aryans, the Turk and the Pathan. Within the polity of Bangladesh there are also small groups of people who retain their distinctiveness and have not merged into the mainstream Bangla-speaking group.

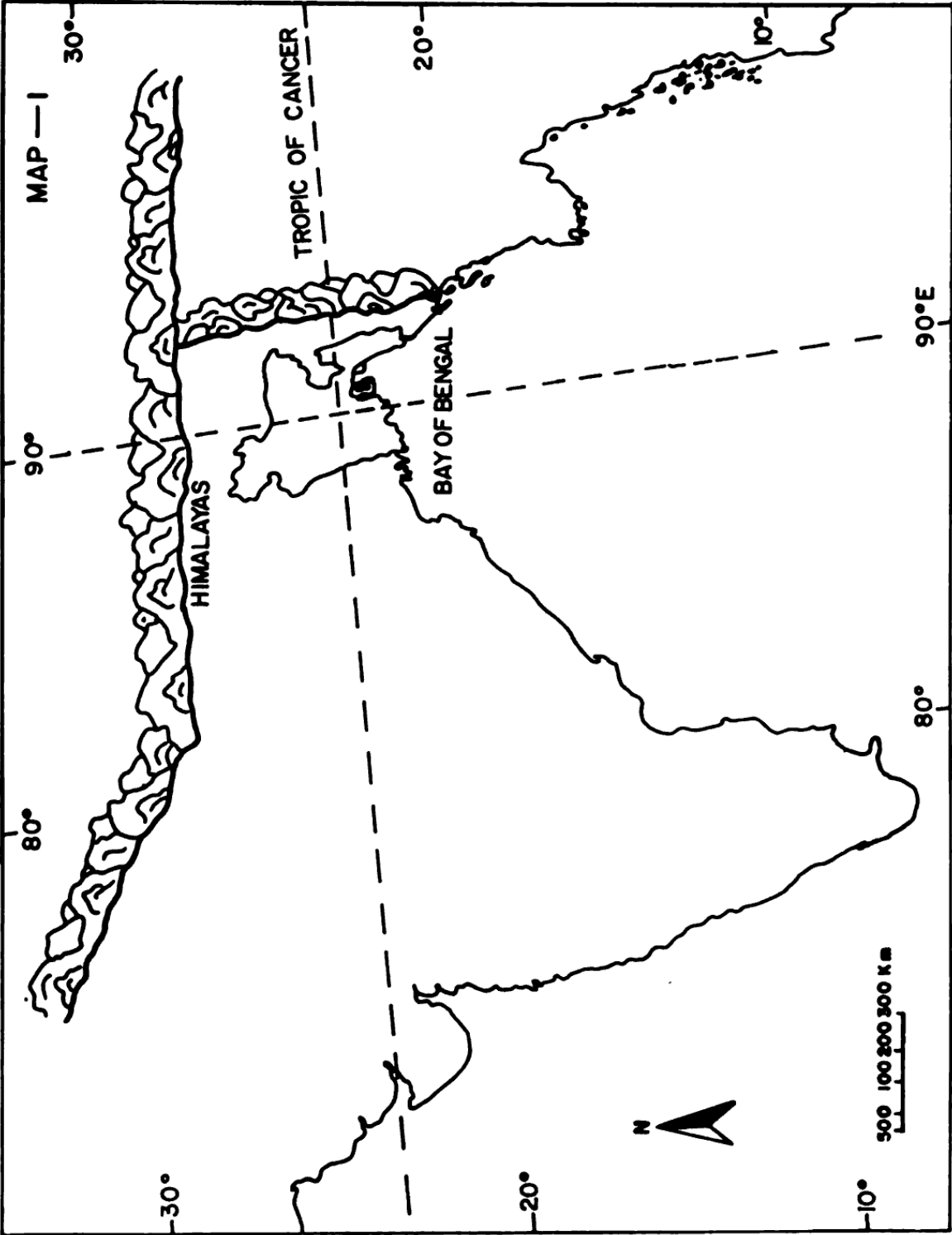
Most of these groups (often called tribes) are mainly of Mongoloid origin and they speak languages of the Tibeto-Burman family of Languages. The most widespread of these are the Koch, who may have been one of the major sources of the Bengali mixture. Then there are Polia, Mande (Garo), Hajong, Tipra, Chakma, Lushai, Mru, Tanchanga, Marma, Rakhine, and other smaller groups. There are also some groups which do not speak languages of the Tibeto-Burman family, but belong to the Austric Mone-Khmer group, such as the Khasia, or to the Dravidian group, such as the Saontal and Oraon. Some of them have been here for several thousand years, whereas others have oral traditions of having come in from Myanmar only six hundred years ago. Yet others, like the Saontals, have come only two centuries back. All these groups have, in some way or another, contributed to the present-day composition of the heterogeneous group known as Bengalis.

The anthropological situation in Bangladesh is therefore one of the great diversity producing a majority group which is very mixed both in physical features and in cultural antecedents but is united despite this diversity through the use of the mellifluous and culturally rich Bangla language. It is also of great sociological significance that despite the overwhelming presence of a majority group with a dynamic culture (the Bengalis) the relatively tiny "tribal" groups have continued as distinct cultural entities, not only along the peripheral areas but deep inside.

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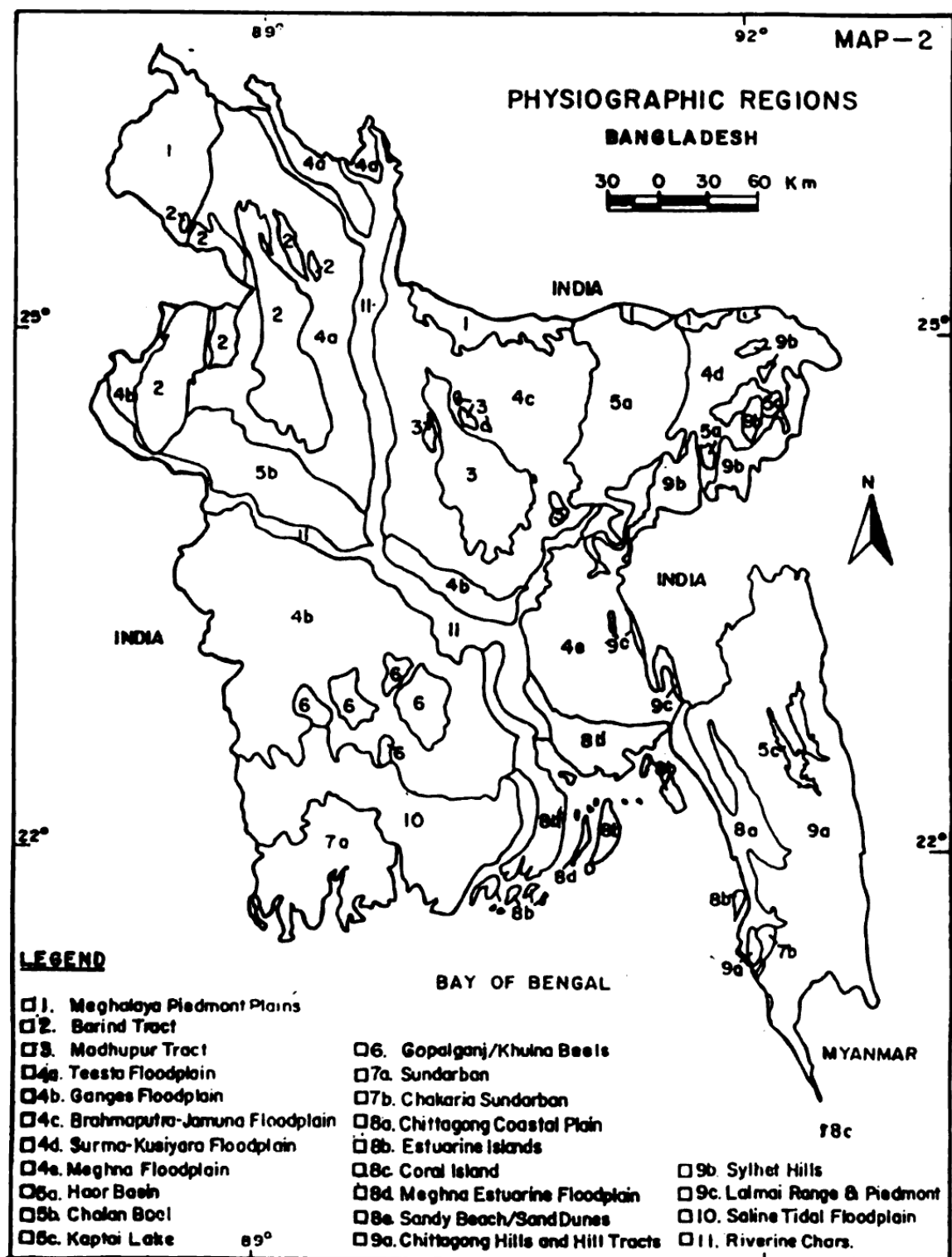
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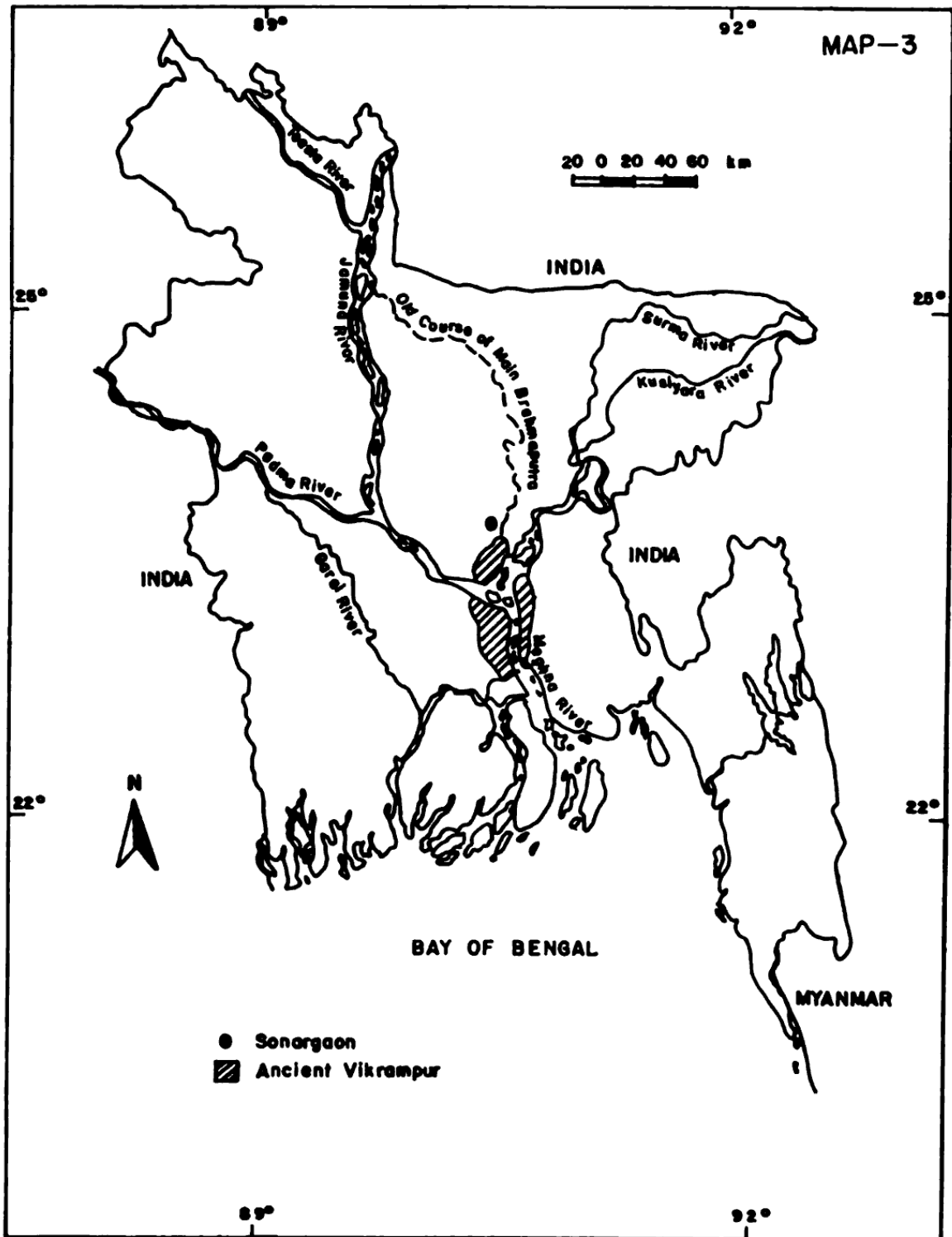


Map 1: Tropic of Cancer

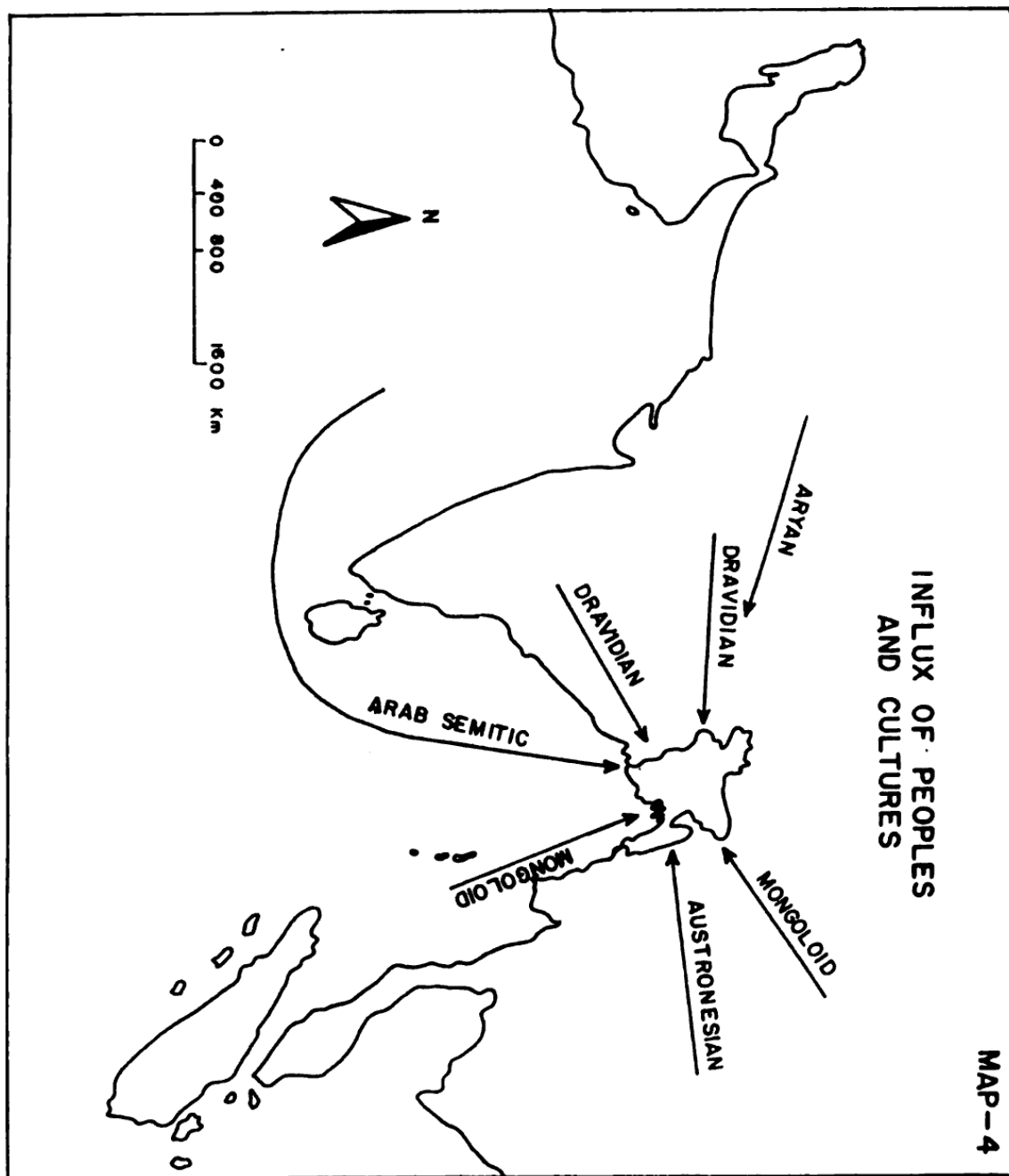




Map 2 : Different Tracts



Map 3 : Shows the shift of course of the river Brahmaputra



Map 4 : Route of ancient migration